

4.2 Prerequisites

For the platform and environment we used EasyPHP version 1.8, which we've provided on the *Digit* CD. The main reason for using EasyPHP is ease of use—it installs The Apache Web Server and MySQL automatically, and configures everything, making your job as a relative beginner infinitely simpler. EasyPHP is not greedy for resources, so a system that is even a couple of years old will easily handle all the applications thrown at it.

PHP is a programming language, unlike HTML, which is simply a markup tool, and PHP can even be embedded inside an HTML document. As you will see in the examples later on in this chapter, PHP code is distinguished as executable by the PHP interpreter on the basis of it encountering “<?php”. This signifies that the following lines are actually PHP code, and the execution is terminated by “?>”. This combination can be used multiple times in a document: each time, the proper beginning and termination encapsulate PHP code, while the remaining body of the document can contain HTML. This is what we mean by “embeddable.” Clicking on “View Source” in your browser doesn't do anything except display HTML code. This is because PHP scripts are executed on the server (since PHP is server side and the installation resides there), and the resulting HTML is sent to the browser on the workstation from where the execution commenced.

PHP code can be written in Notepad, and many HTML editors support it as well.